

VOCABULARY DEVELOPMENT

***Topic*:** Words Associated with Religion

***Focus*:** Christian, Islamic, and Traditional Religion

***Class*:** SS1

1. Introduction

Religion is a belief in and worship of a god or gods. In Nigeria, the three main religions are Christianity, Islam, and Traditional Religion. Each religion has special words we must know to understand passages, answer questions, and speak respectfully.

2. Christian Religious Vocabulary

These are words commonly used in Christianity.

Word	**Meaning**
Bible	The holy book of Christians containing the Old and New Testaments
Church	The building where Christians gather to worship
Pastor	A minister in charge of a Christian congregation
Choir	A group of singers in a church
Pulpit	A raised platform in a church where the pastor preaches
Tithe	One-tenth of income given to the church
Crucifix	A cross with the figure of Jesus on it
Baptism	The Christian ceremony of using water to welcome a person into the church
Christmas	The yearly celebration of the birth of Jesus Christ
Easter	The yearly celebration of the death and resurrection of Jesus Christ

3. Islamic Religious Vocabulary

These are words commonly used in Islam.

Word	**Meaning**
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Qur'an	The holy book of Muslims, revealed to Prophet Muhammad
Mosque	The building where Muslims gather to pray and worship
Imam	The Muslim leader who leads prayers in a mosque
Allah	The Arabic name for God used by Muslims
Salat	The practice of ritual prayer five times daily
Ramadan	The ninth month of the Islamic calendar when Muslims fast
Hajj	The pilgrimage to Mecca that every able Muslim must make once
Muezzin	The person who calls Muslims to prayer from the minaret
Tasbeih	Prayer beads used by Muslims to count recitations
Eid	A Muslim festival, e.g. Eid al-Fitr and Eid al-Adha

4. Traditional Religious Vocabulary

These are words commonly used in African Traditional Religion.

Word	**Meaning**
Shrine	A holy place where a deity or ancestor is worshipped
Deity	A god or goddess in traditional religion, e.g. Amadioha, Sango
Ancestor	A deceased family member believed to protect the living
Diviner	A person who discovers hidden knowledge by spiritual means
Libation	The act of pouring a drink on the ground to honour gods or ancestors
Sacrifice	An offering of animals, food, or other items to a deity
Oracle	A place or person through which deities are believed to speak
Masquerade	A masked dancer believed to represent ancestral spirits
Totem	An animal or plant that serves as the emblem of a family or clan
Priest/Priestess	A person who performs rituals and serves a deity at a shrine

5. General Religious Words

These words are used in all three religions:

1. *Worship* – To show deep respect and love for a god.
2. *Faith* – Strong belief in religious teachings.
3. *Prayer* – Speaking to God or a deity.
4. *Holy* – Sacred, set apart for religious use.
5. *Devotee* – A person strongly committed to a religion.
6. *Pilgrimage* – A religious journey to a sacred place.

6. Quick Exercise

Fill in the blanks with the correct word:

1. Muslims go to the *_*__ to pray.
2. The *_*__ read from the Bible on Sunday.
3. *_*__ is poured to honour ancestors in traditional religion.
4. Christians celebrate *_*__ to mark the resurrection of Jesus.
5. The *_*__ is the holy book of Islam.

Answers: 1. mosque 2. pastor 3. Libation 4. Easter 5. Qur'an

7. Note to Remember

Use religious words with respect. In essays and comprehension, spelling matters: it's *Qur'an* not _Koran_, *mosque* not _mosqe_. Knowing these words improves your understanding of literature and social studies too.